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Childcare Staff Handbook Template

Ready-to-customize staff handbook template for licensed childcare centers. Covers employment policies, conduct standards, ratios, and emergency procedures.

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Ready-to-customize staff handbook template for licensed childcare centers. Covers employment policies, conduct standards, ratios, and emergency procedures.

- ☐ Confirm attendance dates match room records.
- ☐ Mark ratio notes that support licensing review.
- ☐ Attach subsidy claim evidence before filing.
- ☐ Keep guardian and pickup updates with the child record.

How to Use This Template

Fill in every section marked with brackets. Replace [CENTER NAME] with your program's legal name, [STATE] with your state, and [DATE] with the effective date of your handbook. Have your employment attorney review the employment policy sections before finalizing. Collect a signed acknowledgment from every employee and retain it in their personnel file.

[CENTER NAME] Staff Handbook

Effective Date: [DATE] **Version:** [VERSION NUMBER]

Section 1: Welcome and Mission

Welcome Letter

Dear [CENTER NAME] Team Member,

Welcome to [CENTER NAME]. We are glad you chose to work with us. The families who trust us with their children deserve consistency, warmth, and professionalism every day — and that starts with every person on our team.

This handbook explains our policies, your responsibilities, and the standards we hold ourselves to. Please read it carefully. If you have questions about anything in it, ask your director before signing the acknowledgment at the end.

We are committed to providing you with a safe, supportive workplace and a clear understanding of what is expected. In return, we ask for your best work, your reliability, and your commitment to the children and families in our care.

[DIRECTOR NAME] Director, [CENTER NAME]

Our Mission

[CENTER NAME]'s mission is to [INSERT YOUR MISSION STATEMENT — example: provide high-quality, nurturing care that supports every child's development and gives families the confidence that their children are safe, loved, and learning].

Our Values

- [VALUE 1 — example: Safety first, always]
 - [VALUE 2 — example: Respectful relationships with children, families, and each other]
 - [VALUE 3 — example: Continuous learning and growth]
 - [VALUE 4 — example: Consistent, high-quality care every day]
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Section 2: Employment Policies

At-Will Employment

Employment at [CENTER NAME] is at-will. This means either you or [CENTER NAME] may end the employment relationship at any time, for any reason or no reason, with or without notice, subject to applicable law. Nothing in this handbook changes the at-will nature of your employment.

Equal Opportunity

[CENTER NAME] is an equal opportunity employer. We do not discriminate in hiring, compensation, promotion, or any other term of employment on the basis of race, color, religion, sex, national origin, age, disability, sexual orientation, gender identity, or any other characteristic protected by applicable law.

Probationary Period

All new employees complete a [60/90]-day introductory period. During this period, your performance will be evaluated and you will receive training. Completion of the introductory period does not guarantee continued employment or change the at-will nature of your employment.

Work Hours and Scheduling

[CENTER NAME] operates [HOURS OF OPERATION]. Your scheduled shift will be provided in advance. Schedule changes require [X DAYS/HOURS] notice when possible. Schedules are posted [WHERE/HOW].

Staff are expected to arrive at their scheduled start time, not at or after. Ratio coverage depends on each person being present when they are scheduled.

Overtime

Non-exempt employees are eligible for overtime pay at 1.5 times their regular rate for hours worked over 40 in a workweek, in accordance with the Fair Labor Standards Act and [STATE] law. Overtime must be approved in advance by the director.

Attendance and Punctuality

Reliable attendance is critical in a childcare setting. When you are absent, the center must find coverage — unplanned absences directly affect the children and your co-workers.

- Notify the director at least [X HOURS] before your shift if you are unable to come in.
- Excessive absences or repeated late arrivals may result in disciplinary action up to and including termination.
- ☒ unexcused absences within [X]-month period is grounds for termination.

Benefits Summary

- **Paid Time Off:** [INSERT PTO POLICY — example: Full-time employees accrue X hours per pay period after 90 days]
 - **Holidays:** [LIST OBSERVED HOLIDAYS]
 - **Health Insurance:** [INSERT ELIGIBILITY AND COVERAGE SUMMARY, or “not currently offered”]
 - **Retirement:** [INSERT 401(k)/SIMPLE IRA details, or “not currently offered”]
 - **Professional Development:** [INSERT — example: Center pays for required training hours; staff may request approval for additional conferences]
 - **Childcare Discount:** [INSERT — example: Full-time staff receive X% tuition discount for enrolled children]
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Section 3: Conduct Standards

Professional Conduct

Every staff member represents [CENTER NAME] to the families we serve. Professional conduct is expected at all times while on center property, at off-site activities with children, and in any context where your role at [CENTER NAME] is known.

Required professional behaviors:

- Treat every child with patience, warmth, and respect.
- Address parents courteously even when conversations are difficult.
- Resolve disagreements with co-workers privately and respectfully.
- Maintain confidentiality of all information about children and families.
- Report concerns about child safety through proper channels immediately.

Prohibited behaviors:

- Using physical discipline of any kind (including spanking, grabbing, shaking, or restraining).
- Yelling at or belittling children.
- Sharing information about children or families on social media or with unauthorized persons.
- Reporting to work impaired by alcohol or any substance.
- Accepting gifts or tips from families beyond nominal value ([CENTER NAME] definition: more than \$[AMOUNT]).

Cell Phone Policy

Personal cell phones must be [STORED OUT OF SIGHT / KEPT ON SILENT / KEPT IN LOCKERS] during working hours with children. Cell phone use while responsible for children is prohibited. This includes texting, social media browsing, and phone calls, unless there is a genuine emergency.

Exception: You may use your phone during your designated break time in the break room or another area without children.

Repeated violations of the cell phone policy will result in disciplinary action. This policy exists because children's safety depends on undivided staff attention.

Social Media Policy

Do not post photos, videos, or identifying information about children in your care on any personal social media account. This includes photos taken on personal devices even if faces are not shown. Parent consent forms do not authorize personal staff social media posts.

Do not post complaints about [CENTER NAME], its families, or co-workers on social media. Concerns should be raised directly with the director.

Violations of this policy may result in immediate termination.

Dress Code

Staff should dress appropriately for active engagement with children. Specific requirements:

- Closed-toe shoes required at all times.
- Clothing should allow for floor play, lifting, and outdoor activity.
- No clothing with offensive graphics or language.
- [CENTER NAME] logo shirts/uniform: [INSERT REQUIREMENTS — required daily / provided to staff / purchased at cost / optional]
- Fingernails should be kept short enough not to scratch children during caregiving.

Mandatory Reporting

[CENTER NAME] is a mandatory reporter site. Every staff member is legally required to report suspected child abuse or neglect — not to investigate, but to report. If you observe signs of abuse or neglect (on a child in our care or any child), report immediately to the director AND to [STATE CHILD PROTECTIVE SERVICES — INSERT PHONE NUMBER AND WEBSITE].

You do not need proof to report. You need reasonable suspicion. The child protective agency investigates; your job is to report. Failure to report is a crime in [STATE] and will result in immediate termination.

Section 4: Ratio and Supervision Requirements

State Licensing Ratios

[CENTER NAME] is licensed by [STATE LICENSING AGENCY] under License #[LICENSE NUMBER]. All staff are responsible for understanding and maintaining required ratios at all times.

[STATE] requires the following minimum staff-to-child ratios:

Age Group	Ratio	Maximum Group Size
Infant (under 12 months)	[1:X]	[X]
Young Toddler (12-24 months)	[1:X]	[X]
Older Toddler (24-36 months)	[1:X]	[X]
Preschool (3-4 years)	[1:X]	[X]
Pre-K/School Age (5+ years)	[1:X]	[X]

Fill in the table above with your state’s specific ratios. Do not leave it blank.

Supervision Standards

- Children must be within sight and hearing of a qualified staff member at all times.
- “Within sight and hearing” means you can see and respond to every child in your group without delay. This is not satisfied by periodic check-ins.
- You cannot be “in ratio” if you are in a different room, on the phone, or engaged in a task that prevents direct observation of children.
- The director counts toward ratio only when physically present in the classroom and actively supervising.
- Nap time does not reduce ratio requirements. Sleeping children still require supervision.

Break Coverage

Breaks must be covered before you leave your post. Do not leave your classroom for any reason — break, restroom, or other — until a qualified replacement is physically in the room with the children.

If coverage does not arrive at your scheduled break time, notify the director. Do not leave children unsupervised to find your own coverage.

Mixed-Age Groups

When children of different age groups are combined (during arrival, departure, or low-enrollment periods), the entire group must meet the ratio requirement for the youngest child present.

Section 5: Emergency Procedures

Fire Evacuation

1. Upon hearing the fire alarm, immediately direct children to the nearest exit. Do not stop for personal belongings.
2. Take the classroom attendance sheet and the emergency contact binder.
3. Proceed to the designated assembly area: [LOCATION — example: the far corner of the parking lot, away from the building].
4. Take attendance using the attendance sheet. Account for every child before reporting to the director.
5. Do not re-enter the building until the director announces it is safe.
6. The director (or designee) calls 911 if the alarm is not already triggering emergency services.

Monthly fire drills are required by [STATE] licensing. Document each drill: date, time, number of children, staff present, any issues noted, and evacuation time. File drill documentation in the emergency drill log.

Lockdown Procedure

A lockdown is declared by the director when there is a threat inside or immediately outside the building.

1. Move all children away from windows and doors to an interior wall or designated safe area.
2. Lock or barricade the classroom door.
3. Turn off lights. Keep children quiet and calm.
4. Do not open the door for anyone until the director or law enforcement gives the all-clear.
5. Silence your cell phone but keep it available for communication from the director.
6. Do not call parents or post on social media during an active lockdown. The director manages family communication.

Child Injury or Illness

If a child is injured:

1. Assess the situation. If life-threatening: call 911 immediately, then notify the director.
2. For non-emergency injuries: provide first aid appropriate to your training level. Do not leave the child unattended.
3. Complete an incident report form the same day. Document the injury, how it occurred, what action was taken, and when the parent was notified.
4. Notify the parent/guardian by [phone/in person at pickup — specify your policy]. Do not wait until pickup if the injury is significant.
5. If an injury requires medical attention beyond your first aid capabilities, call 911.

If a child appears ill:

1. Separate the child from the group to a supervised area where they can rest.
2. Notify the director.
3. Contact the parent/guardian for pickup. Document the call time and who was reached.
4. Follow [CENTER NAME]'s illness exclusion policy (see your parent handbook). Do not make exceptions.

Severe Weather

[INSERT YOUR STATE/REGION-SPECIFIC SEVERE WEATHER PROCEDURE — tornado, hurricane, etc. Include shelter location and signal.]

Section 6: Incident Reporting

What to Report

All of the following require a written incident report:

- Any injury to a child, including minor injuries (cuts, bumps, bites)
- A child biting another child
- A child leaving the classroom or building without authorization
- A medication error
- A situation in which a ratio was not maintained
- Any incident that required calling 911 or transporting a child for medical care
- Property damage
- Any situation you believe should be documented

When in doubt, write the report. Over-documentation is never a problem.

How to Report

1. Complete the incident report form the same day the incident occurred. Do not wait.
2. Include: child's name, date and time, description of what happened (who-what-where-when), any injury description, action taken, staff present, parent notification time and how they were notified.
3. Give the completed form to the director for review and signature.
4. The director determines if the incident requires reporting to the licensing agency.

Some incidents must be reported to the state licensing agency within 24 hours.

The director will make this determination. Do not contact the licensing agency independently without director involvement.

Section 7: Staff Credential Requirements

Background Checks

All staff must have completed all required background checks before having unsupervised access to children. [CENTER NAME] requires:

- [STATE] criminal background check
- FBI fingerprint-based background check
- [STATE] child abuse and neglect registry check
- Sex offender registry check

Background checks must be renewed every [X years] per [STATE] licensing requirements. [CENTER NAME] will notify you in advance when renewal is approaching. Failure to complete renewal before expiration will result in removal from the schedule until clearances are current.

CPR and First Aid Certification

All [lead teachers / all staff — specify] must maintain current CPR and First Aid certification. Certification must be in-person (not online-only) from an approved provider such as American Red Cross or American Heart Association.

CPR certifications expire every 2 years. First Aid certifications expire every 2 years. Track your expiration dates and begin the renewal process at least 30 days before expiration.

At least one CPR/First Aid certified staff member must be present at the center at all times. If you are the only certified person on shift, you may not leave the premises until a certified colleague arrives.

Required Training Hours

[STATE] requires [X] training hours per year per staff member. [CENTER NAME] [will pay for / reimburse / schedule time for] required training. Training must cover topics approved by [STATE LICENSING AGENCY].

Document all training: date, topic, trainer or organization, hours completed. Provide documentation to the director within [X days] of completing training.

Health Requirements

Within [30/60] days of hire, all staff must provide documentation of:

- [TB test or health screening — specify your state's requirement]
- [Any other health documentation required by your state]

Director Qualifications

The center director must meet [STATE] qualifications for the director role, including: [INSERT — example: a minimum of an associate's degree in ECE or related field, X years of experience, and X training hours per year].

Section 8: Acknowledgment and Signature

I, the undersigned, acknowledge that I have received, read, and understand the [CENTER NAME] Staff Handbook. I understand that:

1. This handbook describes current policies and my responsibilities as an employee of [CENTER NAME].
2. This handbook is not a contract of employment. My employment remains at-will.
3. [CENTER NAME] may revise these policies at any time. I will be notified of significant changes and asked to sign an updated acknowledgment.
4. Questions about any policy should be directed to the director.

I agree to comply with the policies in this handbook and understand that violations may result in disciplinary action, up to and including termination.

Employee Printed Name: _____

Employee Signature: _____

Date: _____

Director Signature: _____

Date: _____

Retain the signed original in the employee's personnel file. Provide the employee with a copy.